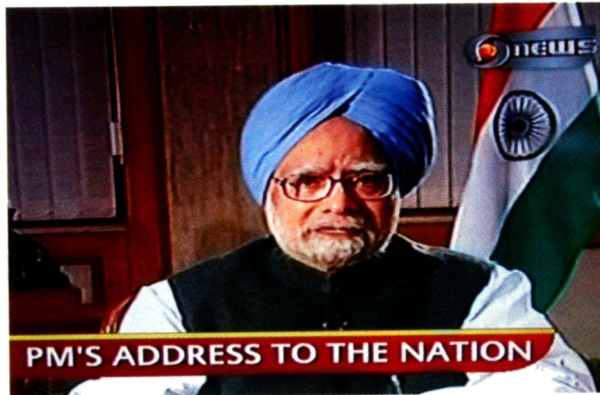


DELHI | Read My Placards

Even as terrorists were holding Mumbai and the country to ransom on November 27, Prime Minister Manmohan Singh was made to wait for three hours by inept Doordarshan staff before he could address the nation. Scheduled to begin his address at 4.30 p.m., Manmohan could start only at 7.30 p.m.. The reason—the technician who operates the teleprompter was on leave, attending a prayer ceremony for a deceased family member. So were apparently all the other technical staff in the department who were able to handle the machine.

As the nation was waiting, it was impossible to cancel the crucial address. Panicky PMO officials, coordinating with Ministry of Information and Broadcasting, arranged for the prime minister's speech to be written out in huge letters on placards. When the speech began, the officials, in an act of very



A DD TECHNICAL GLITCH ALMOST RUINED MANMOHAN'S SPEECH

skilful coordination, kept changing the placards as Manmohan read them out. Fortunately, the officials got the sequence of the speech dead right. Had there been any more human glitches then, Manmohan's cup of woes would have run over. No one in Doordarshan, by the way, has lost his job.

by Bhavna Vij-Aurora

Party Hard

There are some lessons Rahul Gandhi is yet to imbibe from his mom. Sonia will not celebrate her 62nd birthday on December 9 to commiserate with the Mumbai victims. No such thoughts for Rahul who partied till dawn on November 30 at a farmhouse wedding in Delhi.

KOLKATA | Twisted Tale

Industrialist Ashok Todi, a prime accused in the Rizwanur Rehman death case, surrendered on December 1 at a city court. The Todis had objected to their daughter marrying Rehman and had allegedly put police pressure to bring her home. Rehman was found dead on September 21, 2007. The then commissioner of police, Prasun Mukherjee, was transferred after a CBI inquiry. Todi claimed that his family did not force Rehman to "commit suicide". *by Elora Sen*

BANGALORE |

Barking Byte

V.S. Achutanandan's photo-op visit to slain NSG commando Major Sandeep Unnikrishnan's house has earned him neither brownie points nor admirers. After an advance security team tried to search the house of slain hero, the senior Unnikrishnan turfed the Kerala chief minister out. The chief minister



ACHUTANANDAN (RIGHT)

then declared "had it not been a martyr's house, even a dog would not have gone that way". There were protests over the statement Achutanandan's effigies were burnt. He still refuses to apologise.

by Swagata Sen



PTI

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